VAPPALA PANGUNNI MENON

1893–1965



Starting at the bottom

Menon was born into a large landed family in present-day Kerala. He had a mostly pleasant childhood that ended abruptly when, at the age of thirteen, he set fire to his school in anger after being penalized for poor attendance. He subsequently ran away from home, which was the start of a life that would take him all over India, from the Kolar gold mines in Karnataka to Bombay and Simla. He entered government service as a typist at the age of twenty-one, and quickly built up a reputation for thoroughness and excellence, which earned him a permanent position in the British Indian government.